Country Profile: Bosnia and Herzegovina

Nation-Building Policies Dataset

- Number of groups in country: 4
- Plurality religion: Sunni Islam
- Official language: Bosnian, Croatian, and Serbian
- Official religion: None
- Core group: Following the 1995 Dayton Agreement, Bosnia and Herzegovina recognizes three constituent peoples: Bosniaks, Serbs, and Croats. The country's political structure guarantees representation for each of these ethnic groups.

Historical Background

Bosnia and Herzegovina was part of Yugoslavia until that country's breakup in the early 1990s. The breakup was accompanied by a war, during which Bosnia and Herzegovina became the scene of ethnic conflict between Bosniaks, Serbs, and Croats. The Bosnian War, which took place from 1992 to 1995, resulted in widespread ethnic cleansing, genocide, and population displacements. The war ended with the signing of the Dayton Agreement in 1995.

Bosnia and Herzegovina has a bicameral legislature and a three-member presidency, with each member representing one of the major ethnic groups. However, the power of the central government is significantly limited due to the country's extensive decentralization. Bosnia and Herzegovina is composed of two autonomous entities—the Federation of Bosnia and Herzegovina and Republika Srpska—and a third administrative unit, the Brčko District, which is governed by its own local administration.

Groups

- **Bosniaks** are the largest ethnic group (50%) in Bosnia and Herzegovina and one of the three constituent peoples.[1] They adhere to Sunni Islam[2] and speak the Bosnian language, a variant of the Serbo-Croatian macrolanguage.[3] Bosniaks

[1] Agency for Statistics of Bosnia and Herzegovina, 2019.
[2] ARDA, 2020.
[3] Ethnologue, 2024.

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primarily reside in the central parts of the country with some enclaves in the northern regions bordering Croatia.[4]

- **Serbs** are the second largest ethnic group (30%) in Bosnia and Herzegovina and one of the three constituent peoples.[5] The Serbian variant of the Serbo-Croatian macrolanguage, along with adherence to the Serbian Orthodox Church, is a key marker of their common identity.[6] Serbs in Bosnia and Herzegovina are predominantly concentrated in the Republika Srpska region and played an active role in the Bosnian Wars, advocating for independence from Bosnia and Herzegovina.[7] These self-determination aspirations remain salient today.[8]
- **Croats** are the third largest ethnic group in Bosnia and Herzegovina, making up about 15% of the population, and they are recognized as one of the country's three constituent peoples.[9] They mainly follow Roman Catholicism and primarily speak the Croatian language, a part of the Serbo-Croatian macrolanguage.[10] Croats are predominantly concentrated in the Herzegovinian southwest, with smaller populations in central Bosnia and the northern Posavina region. Due to the war, many migrated to Herzegovina or emigrated to Croatia.[11] After the breakup of Yugoslavia, self-determination sentiments among Croats in Bosnia and Herzegovina, supported by Croatian authorities, played a significant role in the Bosnian Wars. Following the Dayton Agreements, Croats have continued to engage in the active self-determination movement.[12]
- **Roma** fall under the category of "others" within the legal framework of Bosnia and Herzegovina and constitute a relatively small racialized ethnic group (0.4%).[13] While the majority of the group adheres to Sunni Islam, a significant proportion also follows Roman Catholicism and Eastern Orthodoxy. Most group members

[4] Joshua Project, 2024.
[5] Agency for Statistics of Bosnia and Herzegovina, 2019.
[6] ARDA, 2020; Ethnologue, 2024.
[7] Minority Rights, 2015b.
[8] Sambanis et al., 2018.
[9] Agency for Statistics of Bosnia and Herzegovina, 2019.
[10] Ethnologue, 2024.
[11] Minority Rights, 2015a.
[12] Sambanis et al., 2018.
[13] Minority rights, 2015b.

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speak the Vlax Romani and Balkan Romani variants of the Romani macrolanguage.[14] Most of Roma live in the Tuzla Canton.[15]

State Profile

Official Language

Bosnia and Herzegovina has three official languages: Bosnian, Croatian, and Serbian. These languages are mutually intelligible and are largely based on the same macrolanguage known as Serbo-Croatian. However, they are written using different scripts: Bosnian primarily uses the Latin script; Croatian uses both the Latin and occasionally the Glagolitic script; and Serbian predominantly uses the Cyrillic script, though the Latin script is also used.[16]

The decision to designate these three languages as official was made to reflect the country's multiethnic and multilingual composition, recognizing the linguistic diversity of its population. This linguistic arrangement was established as part of the Dayton Agreement, which ended the Bosnian War in 1995 and laid the foundation for the country's post-war governance structure.

Official Religion

Bosnia and Herzegovina is a diverse country with several widespread religions, reflecting its complex historical and cultural heritage.

Islam: Islam is the most widely practiced religion in Bosnia and Herzegovina. The majority of Bosniaks, who constitute the largest ethnic group in the country, adhere to Islam. The practice of Islam in Bosnia and Herzegovina has been influenced by centuries of Ottoman rule and has resulted in a unique blend of Islamic traditions with local Bosnian customs.

Orthodox Christianity: Orthodox Christianity is practiced primarily by Bosnian Serbs, who are the second-largest ethnic group in the country. The Serbian Orthodox Church is the main religious institution representing Orthodox Christians in Bosnia and Herzegovina.

[14] Ethnologue, 2024.
[15] Minority Rights, 2015b.
[16] Pisker, 2018.

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Catholicism: Catholicism is adhered to mainly by Bosnian Croats, who constitute a significant minority in Bosnia and Herzegovina. The Roman Catholic Church is the principal religious institution for Catholics in the country.

The country's constitution guarantees freedom of religion and ensures equal rights and protections for followers of all faiths. However, tensions and disputes between religious communities have been a part of Bosnia and Herzegovina's complex social and political dynamics, particularly in the aftermath of the Bosnian War in the 1990s.

Education Policies

The overall system of education in Bosnia and Herzegovina is decentralized, but it follows a general structure. Pre-school education is optional and usually begins at the age of three, aiming to prepare children for primary school through a mix of public and private institutions. Primary education is compulsory from age six and spans nine years, split into two phases: the first phase covers grades 1-5, while the second phase includes grades 6-9. Secondary education is voluntary and offers both general and vocational pathways. General secondary education lasts four years and is designed to prepare students for higher education.[17]

Education is conducted mainly in public educational institutions, but it is also organized through **private** schools. Private education in Bosnia and Herzegovina was formally legalized with the adoption of the Framework Law on Primary and Secondary Education in Bosnia and Herzegovina in 2003.[18] Private institutions may be established by domestic and foreign individuals and legal persons, following the principles defined by the Framework Law and other conditions and criteria established in the area of education. In the 2021/2022 school year, 4,789 children attended private primary schools.[19]

The education system in Bosnia and Herzegovina is **segregated** following the Dayton Peace Agreements. In Republika Srpska, education is centralized, while in the Federation of Bosnia and Herzegovina, it is decentralized across 10 cantons, each with the authority to set its own education policies. This decentralized structure has led to ethnically homogeneous curricula in areas dominated by a single ethnic group. Educational segregation in Bosnia and Herzegovina takes three main forms: the "two schools under

[17] Scolaro Database, 2024.
[18] UNESCO, 2021.
[19] European Commission, 2025.

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one roof" system, where students of different ethnicities are physically separated but share the same building; busing children to monoethnic schools to maintain ethnic homogeneity; and teaching "national subjects," which cater to the historical and cultural narratives of a particular ethnic group.[20] While initially intended as temporary post-war measures, the "two schools under one roof" system has been criticized by UN bodies as reinforcing segregation rather than promoting integration.[21]

In February 2004, Bosnia and Herzegovina adopted "The Action Plan on the Educational Needs of Roma and Other National Minorities in Bosnia and Hercegovina" to meet the educational needs of those communities (revised in 2012). There has been a rise in the number of Roma children and children of other ethnic minorities enrolled in schools at all levels of education, including higher education, under the principle of **affirmative action**.[22]

Language Education Policies

Bosnian, **Croatian** and **Serbian** languages were used as languages of instruction from 1995 to 2020 and were offered as optional classes in some other parts of the country between 2002 and 2020. **Romani languages** were not offered as elective subjects in any school in the country, nor were other alternatives provided for learning the language in public educational institutions.[23]

In Republika Srpska, Serbian is prescribed as the medium of instruction. In the Federation of Bosnia and Herzegovina, either Bosnian or Croatian is the official language of instruction, depending on the majority population in the respective area.[24] Since 2002, minority languages have been taught as optional language classes under the 2002 Interim Agreement on the Accommodation of Specific Needs and Rights of Returnee Children, which was signed by all education ministers in Bosnia and Herzegovina, including those from Republika Srpska. This agreement grants students the right to receive education in the "national group of subjects," including language, literature, history, natural sciences,

[20] Methadzovic, 2012.
[21] UN Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination (CERD), 2010.
[22] Ministry for Human Rights and Refugees, n.d., 7.
[23] Civil Rights Defenders, 2017.
[24] Methadzovic, 2012.

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social studies, and religious instruction, provided there are a minimum of 18 students opting for that choice.[25]

According to the law, the founder of a private educational institution is also obliged to fund the maintenance of school facilities, as well as the education of students in the language and script of national minorities.[26]

Religious Education Policies

In the Federation of Bosnia and Herzegovina, religious teaching was officially introduced to the schools as a subject for the first time in 1994, while this happened one year earlier (1993) in Republika Srpska. In the Federation of Bosnia and Herzegovina, religious teaching is optional-obligatory, meaning that parents can choose this school subject, but once it is chosen, it becomes obligatory. In Republika Srpska, religious education is obligatory for all pupils during elementary school, and neither parents nor children have a choice.[27]

In the Federation of Bosnia and Herzegovina's five Bosniak-majority cantons, primary and secondary schools offer Islamic religious instruction as a twice-weekly course, except in Sarajevo Canton, where the course is offered once per week. Alternatively, students may take a course in ethics. In cantons with Croat majorities, Croat students in primary and secondary schools may attend an elective Catholic religion course twice a week or take a course in ethics. In Sarajevo Canton, the Ministry of Education offers Orthodox, Protestant, Islamic, and Catholic religious education. The Republika Srpska Ministry of Education offers Orthodox religious education in elementary and secondary schools. In both Republika Srpska and the Federation of Bosnia and Herzegovina, as well as Brčko, students belonging to a registered religious community that is a minority in the school may enroll in a course focusing on that religious community if there are at least 18 interested students.[28]

Bans and Restrictions

Bosnian: During the war, the National Assembly of Republika Srpska amended the names of several cities and municipalities within its territory to emphasize their Serb

[25] Interim Agreement on Accommodation of Specific Needs and Rights of Returnee Children, March 5, 2002.
[26] UNESCO, 2021.
[27] Marusic, 2011.
[28] US Department of State, 2022.

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identity. This involved adding prefixes like "Srpski" or changing the names entirely, such as Drvar becoming Srpski Drvar and Mostar becoming Srpski Mostar. However, the language issue in Bosnia and Herzegovina is complex due to its Yugoslav history, when Serbo-Croatian was the single language. Following independence, efforts were made to revive and standardize the Bosnian language, which was officially recognized as a separate language only in 1996.[29]

Religious clothing: In 2015, the ban on wearing religious symbols and clothing was introduced. Employees of judicial institutions are prohibited from wearing "religious insignia" at work, including headscarves.[30]

There have been reported cases where permits have not been issued for building religious buildings. For example, in the Bosniak-controlled parts of the Federation, many mosques have been built without official controls, but Catholic and Protestant churches have faced years of official obstruction. In Croat-controlled areas of the Federation, especially in and around Mostar, Muslim and Protestant places of worship cannot be legally built. In the Serb-controlled Republika Srpska, Serbian Orthodox churches can be built, but places of worship of other faiths face much obstruction.[31]

Demographic Engineering and Violence

State-Based Violence

During the war, Bosnia and Herzegovina was broken into three parts, the separatist Republika Srpska, the Croatian state of Herzegovina, and the Muslim Bosniak central government. The central government did not commit any violence against **Bosniaks** during this period. Rather, it was carried out by non-state actors such as Republika Srpska, the Croatian Republic, militias, and irregulars—although usually with support from Serbia or Croatia. Given the NBP dataset's focus on state-based violence, these serious episodes of violence are not included.

The nationalist conflict in Bosnia saw the Bosnian government target members of the other major ethnic groups, particularly Bosnian **Serbs** and **Croats**, during different phases of the war. Initially, in 1992, government forces focused their efforts on Bosnian Serbs, targeting them with violence including executions, rape, forced expulsions,

[29] Mulalic, 2012, 25–26.
[30] US Department of State, 2016.
[31] Djenovic, 2006.

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looting, and the destruction of villages, particularly in eastern and southern Bosnia.[32] In 1993, the conflict shifted toward Bosnian Croats following the breakdown of the alliance between the government and the Croat forces. This violence occurred mainly in central Bosnia, where the fighting between government forces and Bosnian Croats was most intense. The campaign of ethnic cleansing and targeted violence largely ended following the Dayton and Washington peace agreements, which brought an end to hostilities.[33]

Forced Relocations

1992–1995

Bosnian Croat officials estimate that more than 120,000 **Croats** were displaced due to the fighting with Bosnian government forces. In the villages around Travnik and in several other areas, Croatian Defense Council (HVO) forces arranged for the evacuation of the Croatian population whenever they could no longer maintain control over a village or town.[34]

Bosnian government forces were involved in the forced relocation and ethnic cleansing of **Serb** civilians. These actions primarily took place in areas with predominantly Bosniak populations, such as Gorazde, Lukavac, Konjic, and Zenica, where the government troops were resisting Serb offensives. Bosnian prosecutors charged former members of the Bosnian Army with crimes against humanity for attempting to expel Serbs from Konjic and surrounding villages in May 1992.[35] During the 1993 siege of Goražde, Bosniak forces expelled some Serbs from the town while placing others under house arrest.[36] Additionally, during the siege of Sarajevo, Bosniak paramilitary leader Mušan Topalović and his forces abducted and killed mostly Serb civilians living in and around the Sarajevo suburb of Bistrik.[37] These actions formed part of a broader strategy to consolidate control over contested areas during the war.

The UCDP database does not report state-based violence against the Roma population: however, during the war in Bosnia of 1992–1995, the Roma suffered mistreatment at the hands of all parties in the conflict, often being considered agents of the enemy or

[32] UCDP, 2024.
[33] Ibid.
[34] Human Rights Watch, 1993.
[35] Muslimovic, 2019.
[36] Human Rights Watch, 1995.
[37] Hedges, 1997.

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forcefully conscripted. Over 30,000 Bosnian Roma were expelled under ethnic cleansing. Roma were subjected to inhumane conditions in concentration camps, and entire communities were destroyed.

Many Roma were expelled from their hometowns, in particular from towns which are now in the Republika Srpska, and only a small percentage of them have been able to return. Many Roma fled to Western Europe during the war and were forcibly returned without being able to return to their places of origin and were therefore forced into a secondary displacement.

Segregation

According to the ICRC, there were 23 detention facilities operated by the Bosnian government forces. In 1994, the ICRC knew that approximately 1,036 prisoners were being detained in these facilities and had visited some of the detention areas.

Some examples of Bosnian-run concentration/internment camps and associated wartime crimes include:

1) The Čelebići camp, operational from April to December 1992, was a concentration camp in Čelebići, Bosnia and Herzegovina, run by Bosniak and Bosnian Croat forces during the Bosnian War. Approximately 400–700 Serb detainees, mostly civilians, were subjected to murder, torture, sexual assaults, and inhumane treatment. Many prisoners were killed through shootings, stabbings, or beatings.
2) The Musala camp, operated by the Army of the Republic of Bosnia and Herzegovina, detained Bosnian Serbs and Bosnian Croats.
3) Silos, another concentration camp near Sarajevo, held Bosnian Serb and Croat civilians between 1992 and 1996, with prisoners enduring beatings and poor conditions. Despite a proposed exchange in 1992, the Silos camp persisted until January 1996, when it was closed after the Dayton Agreement. In 2011, Bosnian Muslim officials and camp guards were arrested for abuses at Silos, and in 2021, seven were convicted of war crimes and crimes against humanity.[38]

Cultural Elimination

The cultural and religious heritage of Bosnia-Herzegovina suffered extensive devastation during the 1992–1995 Bosnian War, marked by systematic and deliberate attacks.

[38] Nizich, 1994.

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Bosnian Croat/HVO forces targeted Orthodox/Serb religious property in the Posavina and Herzegovina regions, resulting in the destruction of significant monuments such as the Žitomislić monastery and the Serbian Orthodox Cathedral in Mostar in mid-June. The final months of the war brought attacks on Orthodox religious structures as the HVO, Croatian, and Bosnian armies advanced. Additionally, there were assaults by Bosnian Army forces and Muslims/Bosniaks on Bosnian Serb/Orthodox and Bosnian Croat/Catholic sites, including the shelling and burning of the Serbian Orthodox church of St. George at Donja Sopotnica near Goražde and the burning of the Orthodox church of St. Tsar Lazar in Benakovac between Bihać and Sanski Most. The destruction also extended to Catholic sites, such as the mining and burning of the Roman Catholic Church of the Transfiguration of Our Lord in Borovica by Bosnian government forces in 1993. Despite the widespread devastation, during ICTY indictments defendants from all three warring parties presented evidence of orders prohibiting attacks on religious structures of other ethnic groups.[39]

Constitutions and Laws

During the first years of independence, the 1974 Constitution of the Socialist Republic of Bosnia and Herzegovina was still in force, officially recognizing both the Croatian and Serbian languages. The language policy enforced the use of both language variants, with equal status given to the names Serbo-Croatian or Croato-Serbian and to both the Cyrillic and Latin alphabets.[40] A 1971 document declared citizens had the freedom to choose the name of their language, alphabet, and pronunciation, regardless of nationality.[41] The constitution also affirmed universal religious freedom and the separation of church and state.

The 1994 Constitution of the Federation of Bosnia and Herzegovina named Bosniaks and Croats as the constitutive peoples in Article 1.[42] Article 6 designated Bosnian and Croatian in Latin script as official languages. There were also clauses on the universal acknowledgment of religious freedom in Article 2.[43]

The Dayton Agreement, signed in December 1995, brought an end to the Bosnian War and established a framework for peace and stability in Bosnia and Herzegovina. As part of the

[39] Walasek, 2015.
[40] Ivanova, 2012.
[41] Petranović and Zečević, 1987.
[42] Constitution of the Federation of Bosnia and Herzegovina, March 18, 1994.
[43] Ibid.

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agreement, a new constitution was adopted, known as the "Constitution of Bosnia and Herzegovina" or the "Dayton Constitution." This constitution established a complex system of power-sharing among the country's three main ethnic groups. It created institutions such as the Office of the High Representative (OHR) and the Peace Implementation Council (PIC) to oversee the implementation of the agreement and ensure compliance with its provisions. The 1995 Constitution does not recognize any religious denominations; it neither declares the state secular nor makes emphasis on the separation of church and state. It stipulates that all persons within the territory of Bosnia and Herzegovina shall enjoy human rights and fundamental freedoms, including freedom of thought, conscience, and religion.[44]

Citizenship Laws

According to the 1992 Law on Citizenship of Bosnia and Herzegovina, a child acquires citizenship by origin if both parents are citizens, or if one parent is a citizen and the child is born in the Republic, or if one parent is a citizen and the other is stateless and the child is born abroad, and also if a foreign or stateless child is fully adopted by citizens of the Republic.

The 1998 Law on Citizenship of Bosnia and Herzegovina outlines various pathways for acquiring citizenship, emphasizing descent, birth, adoption, and naturalization. Citizenship by descent is granted to children born after the Constitution's entry into force if one or both parents are Bosnian citizens. Citizenship by birth is conferred to children born or found in Bosnia and Herzegovina whose parents are unknown, stateless, or of unknown citizenship. For adults, naturalization is possible for foreigners who have resided in Bosnia for at least eight years, possess knowledge of a Bosnian language, have no serious criminal record, and are willing to renounce their previous citizenship unless a bilateral agreement permits dual nationality. Additionally, facilitated naturalization is available for foreign spouses of Bosnian citizens, children of naturalized parents, and returning emigrants or their descendants, provided they meet specific criteria such as residency and marriage duration. Special cases of naturalization may also occur if individuals are considered to bring particular benefits to the country.[45]

[44] Constitution of Bosnia and Herzegovina, 1995.

[45] Sarajlic, 2013.

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National Anthem(s)

Since 1992, Bosnia and Herzegovina has had two anthems. The first anthem was only available in the Bosnian language.[46] This anthem included references to the national territory "from the sea to the Sava, from the Drina to the Una."

The current national anthem of Bosnia and Herzegovina, which has been used since 1999, does not have official lyrics. The lyrics written in 2009 by the composer of the piece, Dušan Šestić, along with Benjamin Isović, were accepted by a parliamentary commission, yet await official adoption by all levels of government, so the anthem still remains officially without words. While the unofficial lyrics do not mention the different ethnicities or the two administrative areas of Bosnia (the Federation of Bosnia and Herzegovina, which uses the national anthem, and Republika Srpska, which uses their own anthem), the anthem concludes with "We go into the future, together."[47]

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[46] "Jedna si Jedina," 1992.

[47] Nationalanthems.info.

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